

Studio Meridian Architects

Employee Handbook & Studio Guide

Rev. 3 (2017) - partially updated 2021, 2024. PLEASE DO NOT PRINT.

This handbook is a living document. Some sections may be out of date. If something here doesn't match what your PM tells you, ask. Last full review: March 2017.

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1. Welcome

Welcome to Studio Meridian Architects! We're glad you're here. Whether you are joining us as an intern, a designer, or a licensed architect, you are now part of a studio that has been designing civic, educational, and mixed-use buildings since 1998.

This handbook is meant to help you get settled during your first weeks. It covers how we work, who to talk to, and the policies every employee is expected to follow. Please read it all, but don't worry about memorizing it. You will also meet with the Studio Coordinator during your first week to go over your onboarding schedule.

We believe good buildings come from good teams. Ask questions, pin up your work, and don't be afraid to say "I don't know yet."

- Dana Whitfield, Managing Principal

2. About the Studio

Studio Meridian was founded in 1998 by Dana Whitfield and the late Robert Anand. The studio started with four people working out of a converted warehouse and has grown to over twenty staff. Our work focuses on public libraries, K-12 schools, fire and public safety facilities, and mixed-use housing.

We have won several regional design awards, including the 2019 Civic Design Honor Award for the Northgate Branch Library. Current major projects include Riverside Library, Harbor Point Mixed-Use, Cedar Hills Elementary Modernization, and Fire Station 7.

The studio softball team plays Thursday evenings in the summer. Everyone is welcome regardless of skill level. Ask around the studio if you want to join.

3. Staff Directory & Key Contacts

The full staff directory with photos, extensions, and project assignments is on the intranet: <http://intranet.studiomeridian.example/staff/directory.aspx>

NOTE: The intranet was retired during the 2021 move to SharePoint. The current staff list is on the SharePoint "People" page: <https://studiomeridian.sharepoint.example/sites/studio/People>

To call someone in the office, dial their 3-digit extension from any desk phone. Everyone also uses Microsoft Teams for chat. Please keep your Teams status up to date (Available, Busy, In a Meeting, Away) so people know when they can reach you.

Each project has a project page on SharePoint that lists the project team, including the Principal in Charge, Project Manager, Design Manager, Project Architect, and BIM Lead. If you are not sure who is running a project, check the project page first, then ask the Project Manager.

Key contacts

Topic	Contact	Title	Ext.
General questions, building access, supplies, parking	Priya Raman	Office Manager	110
Benefits, PTO, HR policies, harassment reports	Elena Kowalski	HR Manager	111
Onboarding schedule, trainings	Fatima Noor	Studio Coordinator	112
Payroll, direct deposit, W-2	Tom Brennan	Payroll & Accounting Manager	120
Timesheets, expenses	Grace Liu	Accounting Specialist	121
BIM standards, Revit, worksharing	Samir Haddad	BIM Manager	130
Revit families, keynotes, content library	Keiko Tanaka	BIM Coordinator	131
Computers, accounts, printers, plotters	Jordan Pike	IT Support Specialist	141
Data security, lost devices	Luis Ortega	IT Manager	140
Project staffing and assignments	Hannah Morrow	Senior Project Manager	152

For IT requests, you can also email helpdesk@studiomeridian.example. Requests are answered in the order received.

If you don't know who to ask, ask Priya (Office Manager). She will point you to the right person.

4. BIM / REVIT

All production work at Studio Meridian is done in Autodesk Revit 2019. Do not upgrade any project model to a newer version of Revit without approval from the BIM Manager, because an upgraded model cannot be opened by anyone still on the older version.

The Studio Meridian BIM Standards manual is the full reference for templates, naming, worksets, and sheet setup: \\SM-FS01\Standards\BIM\SM_BIM_Standards_v3.pdf

Project files live on the project server under \\SM-FS02\Projects\<project number>\BIM\ . The BIM Lead for each project is responsible for the central model. The BIM Manager (Samir Haddad) is responsible for the firm-wide standards, the Revit template, and the content library.

4.1 Worksharing and the central model

Every Revit project at Studio Meridian is workshared. That means there is ONE central model on the server, and each person works in their own local copy which is synchronized with the central model. The central model is the single source of truth for the whole team. If the central model is damaged, everyone on the project loses work.

Rules for the central model:

- Never open the central model directly to do your daily work. Always work in a local copy.
- Never copy, move, or rename a central model using File Explorer (Windows Explorer). A copied central file still thinks it is the central model. If someone opens the copy and syncs, their work goes to the wrong file and the real central model can become corrupted.
- Never email a central model or put it on a USB drive.
- Only the project BIM Lead may move, rename, or archive a central model, and only by using Revit's Save As with the "Make this a Central Model after save" option.

To start working on a project each day:

1. Open Revit and go to File > Open.
2. Browse to the central model in \\SM-FS02\Projects\<project number>\BIM\Central\.
3. Select the central model and make sure "Create New Local" is checked at the bottom of the Open dialog.
4. Click Open. Revit creates your local copy in C:\Revit_Local\ with your username added to the file name.
5. Work in your local copy.
6. Synchronize with Central at least every hour, and always before lunch and before you leave for the day.
7. When you close the model at the end of the day, choose "Relinquish all elements and worksets" so your teammates can edit what you were working on.

Do not reuse yesterday's local file. Create a new local every morning.

4.2 Making a test copy of a model

Sometimes you need a copy of the project model to study a design option, test a family, or try something out without affecting the team's work. Do NOT copy the central file in File Explorer to do this. Instead:

1. In Revit, go to File > Open and browse to the central model.
2. Check "Detach from Central" at the bottom of the Open dialog.
3. When Revit asks, choose "Detach and preserve worksets".
4. Save the detached model to your project sandbox folder: \\SM-FS02\Projects\<project number>\BIM\Sandbox\ and include your initials in the file name (for example, RL-2301_Option-B_AR.rvt).

A detached model is completely disconnected from the central model. Nothing you do in it can sync back to the team's model. If a design option is approved, talk to the project BIM Lead about bringing it into the central model; do not try to copy elements back yourself.

4.3 Keynotes

Studio Meridian uses Revit keynotes to annotate construction documents. Keynotes are short codes that point to a standard note. The keynote file for the whole firm is SM_Keynotes.txt, stored in \\SM-FS02\Standards\Revit\Keynotes\.

How to read a keynote: our keynotes follow CSI MasterFormat. The first six digits are the MasterFormat section number and the suffix after the period is the Studio Meridian variant. For example, in 09 29 00.A1, "09 29 00" is the MasterFormat section for Gypsum Board, and ".A1" is our note "5/8 in. Type X gypsum board". The keynote legend on each sheet lists every keynote used on that sheet with its full text.

Keynote rules:

- Always place keynotes with the Keynote tag (element or material keynotes). Do not type keynote numbers or note text into a plain text note, because typed notes do not update when the keynote file changes.
- Do not edit SM_Keynotes.txt yourself. If a note is missing or wrong, send the request to the BIM Coordinator (Keiko Tanaka), who maintains the keynote file.
- Every sheet that uses keynotes must include a keynote legend.

4.4 Model practices

- Link CAD files and other Revit models. Do not import them. Never explode an imported CAD file in a project model.
- Do not create in-place families without approval from the project BIM Lead. Use loadable families from the content library.

- Put elements on the correct workset. If you are not sure which workset to use, ask your BIM Lead.
- Keep model warnings under control. Check Manage > Review Warnings before each major issue and fix what you created.
- Views you create for your own work should start with your initials (for example, AR - Level 2 Study) so they can be cleaned up later.

NOTE (2024): All active projects are now on Revit 2025. Check with Samir before opening an older archived project.

5. OFFICE POLICIES & STUDIO ETIQUETTE

Office hours

The studio is open from 7:00 AM to 7:00 PM, Monday through Friday. Core hours are 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM. All full-time staff are expected to be in the studio or available during core hours unless they have approved time off. Outside of core hours you may set your own schedule with your PM's agreement, as long as you work a full week.

Dress code

Our dress code is business casual. On days when clients are visiting the studio or you are attending a client meeting, dress a step up. Site visits require closed-toe shoes; hard hats and safety vests are provided by the contractor or can be borrowed from the supply room.

Workspace

- Keep your desk reasonably tidy. Roll-out drawings at the end of the day and put models away.
- The quiet area near the library is for focused work. Take calls in a phone room or conference room.
- Headphones are fine. If you are wearing them, keep Teams open so people can reach you.
- Please avoid strong-smelling food at your desk.

Kitchen

Everyone cleans up after themselves. Load your own dishes into the dishwasher. The refrigerator is cleaned out every Friday at 3:00 PM; anything unlabeled will be thrown out.

Meetings

Be on time for meetings, both in person and on Teams. If you are presenting, have your drawings or screens ready before the meeting starts. Camera on is preferred for internal Teams meetings.

Design reviews and pin-ups

Studio design reviews are held on Thursdays at 4:00 PM in the main conference room and are led by the Design Principal. Any team can sign up for a slot. Interns are encouraged to attend even if their project isn't presenting. Critique is about the work, not the person: give specific feedback, and receive it without getting defensive.

Plotting and printing

- Check the plot queue before sending a large job.
- Pick up your plots right away. Plots left on the plotter overnight will be recycled.
- Large sets (more than 20 sheets) should be sent after 5:00 PM unless it's a deadline.
- Use the "Check Set" paper for internal reviews and the bond paper only for client and permit sets.

Model shop

The model shop has a laser cutter and power tools. You must complete the shop safety training before using any equipment. Never leave the laser cutter running unattended.

Core hours (reminder)

Core hours are 9:30 AM to 3:30 PM. Please make sure your calendar reflects when you are in the studio.

Parking and building access

Your key card opens the front door and the studio floor. Lost key cards must be reported to the Office Manager the same day. Parking in the garage is available on a first-come basis; ask the Office Manager about a monthly pass.

6. TIMESHEETS

Accurate timesheets are how we bill our clients and how we know if projects are on budget. Every employee, including interns and principals, must submit a timesheet every week. Studio Meridian moved from Deltek Vision to Deltek Vantagepoint in 2022.

Timesheets are due every Friday by 5:00 PM for the current week. Enter your hours every day if you can; it is much easier than trying to remember on Friday.

How to fill out your timesheet:

1. Log in to Deltek Vision from the link on the intranet homepage. (Vision works best in Internet Explorer 11.)
2. Open the timesheet for the current week.
3. For each project you worked on, add a line with the project number and the phase code (for example, RL-2301 / CD for Riverside Library, Construction Documents).
5. Enter your hours for each day on the correct line. Round to the nearest quarter hour.
6. Your Project Manager reviews and approves timesheets on Monday.

Time that is not billable to a project goes to one of the overhead codes:

Code	Use for
OH-ADMIN	General office and admin tasks
OH-TRAIN	Trainings, onboarding, and continuing education
OH-MKTG	Proposals and marketing
PTO	Paid time off
HOL	Firm holidays

Do not charge time to a project you are not assigned to without asking that project's PM first. If you are not sure which project or phase code to use, ask your PM before you submit.

Late timesheets hold up billing for the whole firm. If your timesheet is late, Accounting will contact you and your PM. Repeated late timesheets are addressed in your performance review.

Reminder: all timesheets must be submitted by Monday at 12:00 noon for the previous week.

Questions about the timesheet system, corrections after submitting, or missing project codes go to Grace Liu (Accounting Specialist).

7. PAYROLL

Studio Meridian pays employees every other Friday by direct deposit. Your pay is based on your approved timesheets, so a missing or late timesheet can delay your paycheck.

To set up or change your direct deposit, fill out the Direct Deposit Authorization form and return it to the Payroll & Accounting Manager. Changes take one to two pay periods to take effect.

Pay stubs and W-2 forms are available in the HR portal: <https://hr.studiomeridian.example/portal>

If you think there is a mistake in your paycheck, contact the Payroll & Accounting Manager (Tom Brennan) directly. Please do not discuss pay issues in Teams channels or by group email.

8. PAID TIME OFF (PTO)

Studio Meridian provides paid time off (PTO) for vacation and personal time. Sick leave is tracked separately; see the HR Manager for details.

Accrual

Full-time employees accrue PTO every pay period based on years of service:

Years of service	PTO per year
0 - 2 years	15 days (120 hours)
3 - 5 years	18 days (144 hours)
6+ years	22 days (176 hours)

Part-time employees accrue PTO in proportion to their scheduled hours. Interns do not accrue PTO but may request unpaid time off.

You may carry over up to 40 hours of unused PTO into the next calendar year. Any PTO above 40 hours that is not used by December 31 is forfeited.

Requesting time off

PTO requests must be submitted at least two weeks in advance. For time off longer than one week, please give at least one month's notice. Before you request time off, check your project deadlines; PTO during the two weeks before a major submission may be declined.

How to request PTO:

1. Check your PTO balance in the HR portal.
2. Talk to your Project Manager about your dates and project coverage.
3. HR will confirm your approved time off by email.
4. Put your approved PTO on your Outlook calendar and set your Teams out-of-office message.

When you take PTO, record it on your timesheet with the PTO code.

Holidays

The studio is closed on the following holidays: New Year's Day, Martin Luther King Jr. Day, Memorial Day, Juneteenth, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving Day, the day after Thanksgiving, Christmas Eve, and Christmas Day. Record holidays on your timesheet with the HOL code.

PTO FAQ

Q: How much PTO do I get in my first year?

A: New employees accrue 10 days (80 hours) of PTO in their first year.

Q: Can I take PTO before I've accrued it?

A: Not normally. In special cases, talk to the HR Manager.

Q: How far ahead do I need to request PTO?

A: At least 5 business days before your time off.

Q: Where is the PTO request form?

A: [go/pto-form](#) (old link - will be updated)

9. CONFIDENTIALITY & PRIVACY

As an architecture firm, we are trusted with sensitive information: client plans, building security layouts, budgets, and personal information about our colleagues. Protecting that information is part of everyone's job.

Client and project information

- Treat all project drawings, models, and documents as confidential unless they have been publicly released by the client.
- Some clients require a signed non-disclosure agreement (NDA). Your PM will tell you if a project has one. Do not discuss those projects outside the project team.
- Security-sensitive drawings (for example, fire station and school security plans) may only be shared through the project's secure SharePoint folder, never by personal email.
- Do not discuss project details in public places such as restaurants, trains, or on social media.

Posting project images

Do not post project images, renderings, or photos of the studio's work on social media or in a personal portfolio without written approval from the Design Principal. Some clients do not allow any public images until their project is officially announced.

Devices and data

- Lock your computer (Windows key + L) whenever you leave your desk.
- Do not use personal USB drives on studio computers. Use SharePoint to share files.
- Do not install software on your studio computer yourself. Submit a request to IT.
- If a laptop, phone, or key card is lost or stolen, or you think project data may have been exposed, report it to the IT Manager within 24 hours.

Employee information

Personnel files, pay, medical information, and other personal employee information are handled only by HR and the Payroll & Accounting Manager. If you come across another employee's personal information by mistake, do not share it; let the HR Manager know.

10. HARASSMENT PREVENTION

Studio Meridian is committed to a workplace free of harassment, discrimination, and retaliation. This policy applies to everyone who works with us: employees, interns, principals, consultants, clients, and contractors, in the studio, on job sites, at client meetings, at studio events, and online.

What harassment is

Harassment is unwelcome conduct based on a protected characteristic such as race, color, religion, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity, national origin, age, disability, or veteran status. It includes:

- Offensive jokes, slurs, name-calling, or comments about someone's appearance
- Unwanted touching or physical contact
- Sexual advances, requests for dates after someone has said no, or sexual comments
- Displaying offensive images or messages, including in Teams or email
- Threats, intimidation, or treating someone worse because of who they are

Reporting

If you experience or witness harassment, report it. You can report to:

- The HR Manager (Elena Kowalski), or
- Any principal (Dana Whitfield or Marcus Oyelaran), or
- The anonymous reporting hotline: <https://studiomeridian.ethicsline.example/report> (LINK TBD)

You do not have to report to your supervisor first, and you do not have to report to the person involved. Reports are handled as confidentially as possible and investigated promptly.

No retaliation

Retaliation against anyone who reports harassment in good faith, or who takes part in an investigation, is strictly prohibited and is itself a violation of this policy.

Training

All employees must complete harassment prevention training within 30 days of their start date and every two years after that. New employees should watch the 2017 harassment training video on the DVD in the studio library and sign the acknowledgment form.

Harassment prevention training is required annually for all staff.

The Studio Coordinator schedules trainings and tracks completion.

11. MISC / FAQ

Q: Who do I ask if I don't know who to ask?

A: The Office Manager.

Q: Where do I save my files?

A: Project files go in the project folder on \\SM-FS02\Projects\. Never save project files only on your desktop.

Q: Can I work from home?

A: Talk to your PM. Remote days need to be agreed with your team and cannot fall on client meeting days.

Q: How do I get a Revit license?

A: Revit is installed on all studio workstations. Ask IT if yours is not working.

Q: Where is the BIM Standards manual?

A: See Section 4. If the link doesn't work, ask the BIM Manager for the current version.

Q: Is there a mentorship program?

A: Coming soon!

Q: What if I get hurt at work or on a site?

A: Tell your PM and the Office Manager right away, and fill out an incident report the same day.